

Past participles as adjectives

Past participles can be used on their own as adjectives to modify nouns. They are placed either before the noun or pronoun they describe, or after it, following a linking verb.

This past participle is being used as an adjective before the noun it describes (*skates*).

his broken skates

His skates were broken.

Here, the past participle is being used as an adjective after the noun it describes (*skates*), following the linking verb *were*.

Identifying a gerund phrase

Participle phrases act as adjectives, whereas gerund phrases act as nouns, which can be described by adjectives. Since gerund phrases are always singular, it is possible to check whether a phrase is a gerund phrase by substituting the pronoun *it*.

Emptying his cupboard,
Josh found them.

The pronoun *it* has been substituted for the phrase, and the resulting sentence doesn't make sense, so the phrase is a participle phrase.

It, Josh found them. ❌

Emptying his cupboard,
Josh found them. ✅

This participle phrase is acting as an adjective, describing Josh.

Repairing the skates
was a priority.

The pronoun *it* has been substituted for the phrase, and the resulting sentence makes sense, so the phrase is a gerund phrase.

It was a priority. ✅

Repairing the skates
was a priority. ✅

his broken skates. He had skating, but they were missing.

Present participles as nouns

When the present participle of a verb is used as a noun, it is called a gerund. Like nouns, a gerund (one word) or a gerund phrase (multiple words) can be used as the subject or object of a sentence.

subject

He wanted to do some ice-skating.

The gerund phrase *ice-skating* is acting as the object of this sentence.

Present participles as adjectives

Like past participles, present participles can be used as adjectives. They can be placed before or after the noun or pronoun that they modify.

This present participle is being used as an adjective after the pronoun it describes (*they*), following the linking verb *were*.

They were missing.
the missing skates

This present participle is formed from the verb *miss*, and is describing the noun *skates*.